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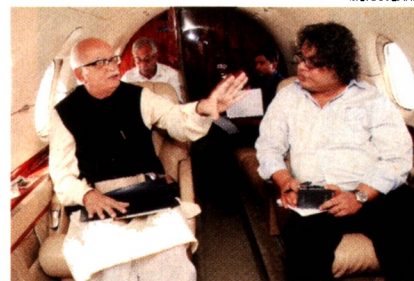
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From the editor-in-chief

I have travelled with L.K. Advani on his campaign trail in the 1989 general elections before the soundbyte age and found him always ready to engage in discussion and debate as against the pre-formulated responses of many leaders. In recent times, my longest meeting with him was in 2006 during an interview for our Newsmaker of the Year issue. That was a few months after his controversial statement when he referred to Pakistan founder Mohammed Ali Jinnah as a 'secular leader', a statement that almost ended his political career. He had been abandoned by his party and its parent organisation, the RSS, branded a "turncoat" and had quit as BJP president. It seemed like the end of days for the ageing patriarch, the founder of the Hindutva movement. Yet, he was relaxed and confident, so much so that in my letter introducing that issue, I wrote: "Something tells me we have not heard or read the last on this man, who, I think, believes he has a tryst with destiny."

Will 2009 be the year he makes that rendezvous? Advani, for all the time spent in Atal Bihari Vajpayee's shadow, has never disguised his prime ministerial ambitions. Even in the wake of the Jinnah debacle, he refused to acknowledge that it was time to retire. Now, as the BJP's official candidate for the top job, his transformation from abandoned leader to prime ministerial candidate is complete. The fire-breathing Hindutva hero is now born-again reconciler, and, more dramatically, a man who is advocating modernity and technology. It's a remarkable makeover for the creator of Hindutva, the man who toured the country on his Ram Rath Yatra in 1990 crusading for a Ram temple in Ayodhya and perfecting the art of divisive politics. It was an 'Iron Man' image which laid the platform for the BJP's spectacular rise to power in the mid '90s and yet today, in the heart of a make-or-break election, arguably his last big political battle, he has chosen a new avatar, one I suspect he is more comfortable with.

The man many described as a Hindu fanatic has always given the impression of being in conflict with the labels he has been saddled with. His sustained Hindutva campaign led to the destruction of the Babri Masjid, and yet he calls it "the saddest day of my life". His most vaunted label was 'Iron Man', and yet, as home minister, he tamely gave in to terrorists who had hijacked an Indian aircraft. I always saw him more professor than revolutionary, a thinker who would argue his case forcefully with that characteristic wringing of hands rather than take to the streets and engage in pitched battles. To gauge his mood, his strategy, his prospects and his connect with voters, Editor-at-Large S. Prasannarajan trailed Advani, clearing doubts on conflicting stands, the most recent being his support for Varun Gandhi. At 81, the man responsible for the defining moments in Indian politics in recent years faces the most challenging battle of his life. Leading a presidential-style campaign, Advani has turned this election into a referendum on himself.



ADVANI WITH PRASANNARAJAN

(Aron Purie)